



The roof and walls of the Reptile House were made from glass to let in sunlight, which is important to keep reptiles healthy.

Creature comforts

Joan set to work creating the best reptile house in the world. To do that, she needed to combine all of her knowledge about how reptile bodies work and the kinds of places they lived in the wild. She added “furniture” that imitated jungle habitats, with caves, real trees, and swimming pools. She had cacti sent over from the United States to make desert snakes feel at home. And to stop mold from growing, the walls were covered in car paint, which was easy to clean, too.

When the new Reptile House opened in 1927, it was a huge success. The reptiles moved around more, grew bigger, and lived longer, happier lives here. Joan’s excellent enclosure is still being used today.

Joan was comfortable around even the largest reptiles, such as the fearsome Komodo dragon.

Reptile thermoregulation

Joan understood that reptiles cannot make their own body heat. They must bask in sunlight to warm up, and sit in shade to cool down. Joan installed human-made sunlamps and heated rocks to help the reptiles control their temperature. This kept the reptiles healthy and cleverly encouraged them to sit where visitors could admire them.

*Joan’s biggest honor was having two reptile species named after her: the snake *Bufo procterae*, and the tortoise *Testudo procterae*.*

Toward the end of her time at the zoo, Joan could only travel around the grounds in a wheelchair, because she was so unwell.